The Brihadishvara temple as it is today, showing the fully restored *vimana* (spire).

In the autumn of 1310 one such force, under the leadership of a Hindu convert to Islam named Malik Naib Kafur, fought its way south into Chola country, looting the temples as it went. Their first target was the complex of the Chola Ranganath temple in Srirangam, which alerted the temple authorities at Chidambaram, who did their best to hide or disperse their most valuable treasures. But that best was not good enough. The subsequent pillaging of Chidambaram was recorded in pious and supposedly scandalised terms by Sultan Ala-ud-Din's Indo-Persian court poet Hasrat Amir Khusrao in his *Khaza'inul futuh* or 'Treasures of Victory':

> The stone idols, called Ling-i-Mahadeo [Shivalingas] which had been for a long time established in that place – to which the women of the faithful behave shamefully – these up to that time the kick of the horse of Islam had not attempted to break. [Now] the Mussulmans destroyed all the lingas. De Narain [Vishnu Narayan] fell down, and the other gods who had fixed their seats there, raised their feet so high, that at one leap they reached the feet of Lanka; and in that affright the lingas themselves would have fled, had they any legs to stand on.[5]

In their determination to secure whatever treasures might have been hidden away the invaders are said to have pulled down the temple's walls and dug up its foundations: 'Wherever there was any treasure in that deserted building, the ground was sifted in a sieve and the treasure discovered.'[6]

Malik Kafur then moved on to Madurai, where he stripped the famous temple of Meenakshi Amman of its golden roof and the golden image of the goddess. 'He destroyed the